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Substack rival Ghost connects to the open social web with its latest public release

After [months of beta testing](#), newsletter platform [Ghost](#) has [shipped](#) a new version of its software, Ghost 6, that allows its publishers to share their long-form content natively with the broader open social web. That means in addition to publishing their newsletters to the web, RSS, and sending them out via email, Ghost's users can also natively connect with services like the decentralized X rival Mastodon; Meta's Threads; Flipboard; WordPress sites that have integrated with ActivityPub, Surf, and WriteFreely; and others.

While Ghost also mentions the ability to publish to Bluesky as a part of this release, that's [made possible](#) through an integration with [Bridgy Fed](#), a service that connects the [open social web known as fediverse](#) to the one called the [ATmosphere](#). The former is powered by an open standard for decentralized social networking called [ActivityPub](#), whereas the latter works with the newer [AT Protocol](#) used by Bluesky and other apps.

[Manton Reece](#), the founder of the publishing platform [Micro.blog](#), pointed out the difference between [his service and Ghost's](#), noting that Micro.blog has been working on direct AT Protocol integration while Ghost is using bridging.

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Manton Reece
@manton.org



Ghost 6.0 has been released, adding ActivityPub. Big update. It's interesting how Ghost now talks about Bluesky compatibility, which works via Bridgy Fed, but they don't mention Bridgy Fed. This feels slightly wrong to me since I've spent so much time working on AT Protocol.

Aug 4, 2025 at 3:21 PM

5 4 2000 View on Bluesky

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ActivityPub has long been used to power open, decentralized social media applications. But in the years after Twitter's acquisition by Elon Musk, there has been an increased interest in building with this protocol as competitors to Twitter (now called X) emerged.

Meta launched its alternative to X in [2023 with Instagram Threads](#), which has been [catching up to](#) X on mobile devices. Meanwhile, blogging platform [WordPress](#), including the hosted version WordPress.com, now offers the ability to integrate with ActivityPub, allowing users to follow WordPress blogs on services like Mastodon. Other apps have integrated with the open social web as well, such as [Flipboard's](#) flagship app and newer app [Surf](#), and [publishing platform Medium](#).

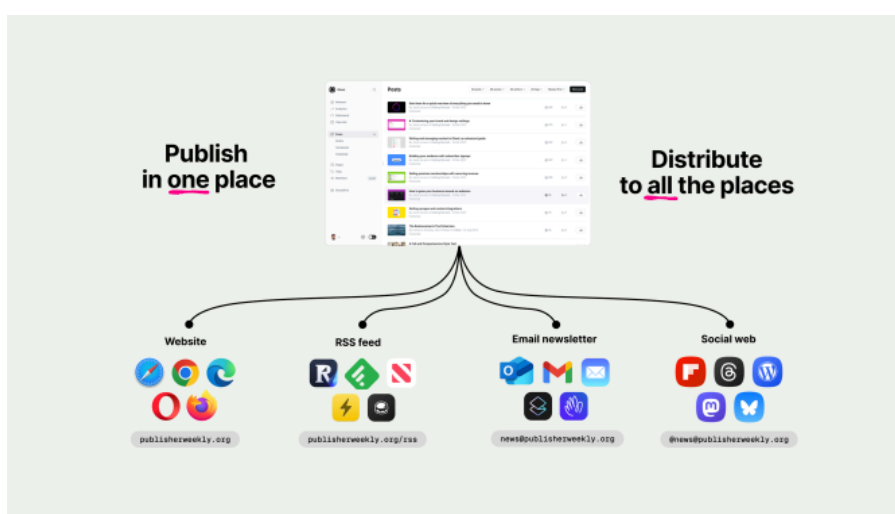


IMAGE CREDITS:GHOST

Ghost also touted the potential network effects of connecting with ActivityPub, because it allows

people on federated apps to then follow a Ghost publisher's posts, as well as interact with them by liking, replying, or reposting. This potentially broadens the publishers' reach and expands their readership.

In addition, Ghost's users can keep up with other long-form content in an "Inbox" section of its software, where they can follow other articles published on Ghost or WordPress. Plus, from Ghost's admin screen, publishers will have the ability to post short-form content to the fediverse, allowing them to grow their following and connect with readers.



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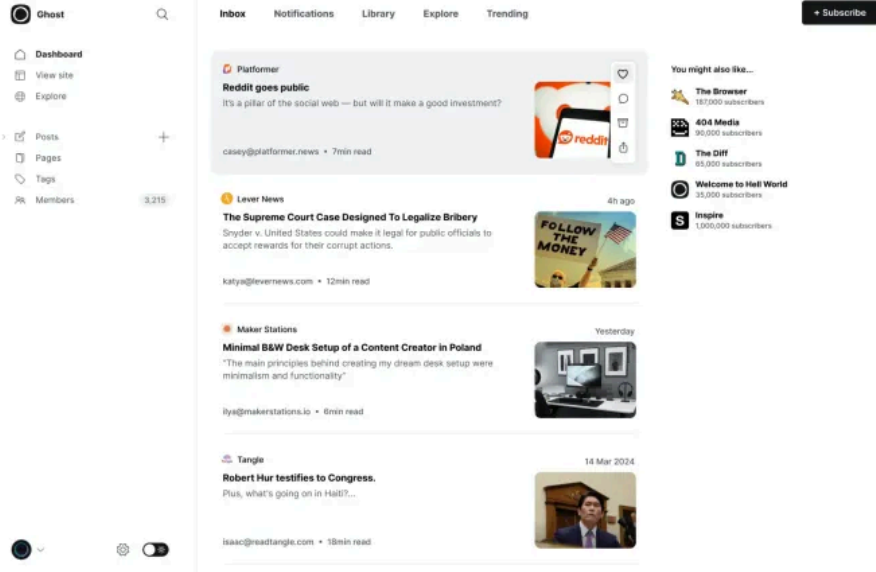


IMAGE CREDITS :GHOST

Ghost 6 arrives shortly after a shameful incident from its top competitor, the newsletter platform Substack, which [sent a push notification](#) to users encouraging them to subscribe to a Nazi newsletter. Several authors have already left Substack over its decision to host such content in the past, including Casey Newton of Platformer, a popular tech publication. Other notable Ghost [publications](#) include [404 Media](#), [Spyglass](#), David Sirota’s [The Lever](#), [Tangle](#), Jason Calacanis’s Inside, SFist, and others.

The company shared that its publishers have generated over \$100 million, leaving Ghost with annual revenue of \$8.5 million.

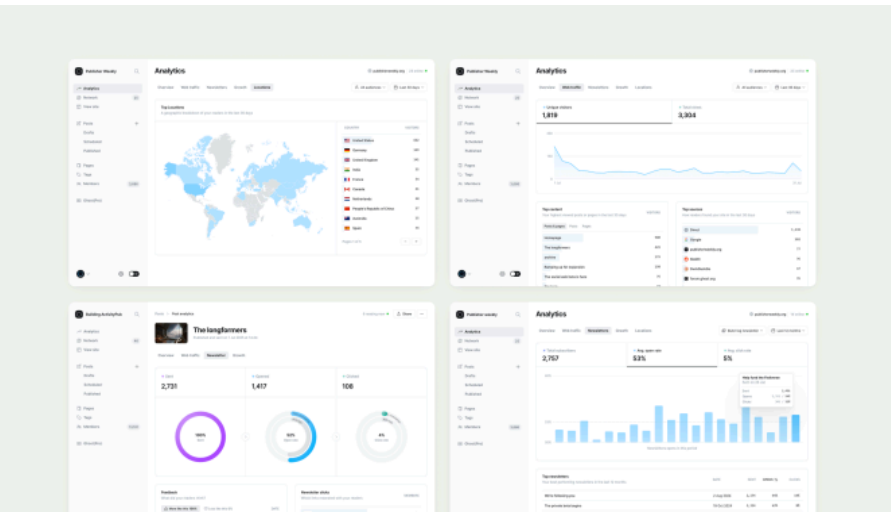


IMAGE CREDITS :GHOST

While the ActivityPub integration is a main selling point for Ghost 6, this major release includes a number of other changes and new additions. Notably, [Ghost now ships with](#) a native analytics suite that tracks performance, engagement, and conversions across the web, newsletters, and subscriptions in real time.

The software also supports a variety of payment methods, tips and donations, branded newsletters, content that can be personalized to individual readers, and more.

With the release, Ghost [adjusted](#) its pricing for its Pro (hosted) plans; its cheapest plans now start at \$15 and \$29 per month, up from \$9 and \$25 per month, respectively. Ghost publishers with a large number of subscribers, however, will now see reduced pricing.

Topics: [activitypub](#) [fediverse](#) [ghost](#)

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Substack rival Ghost federates its first newsletter

Sarah Perez — 10:59 AM PDT · July 8, 2024

Newsletter platform and Substack rival [Ghost](#) [announced earlier this year](#) that it would join the fediverse, [the open social network](#) of interconnected servers that includes apps like Mastodon, Pixelfed, PeerTube, Flipboard and, more recently, [Instagram Threads](#), among others. Now, it has made good on that promise — with its own newsletter as a start.

Over the past few days, Ghost says it has achieved two major milestones in its move to become a federated service. Of note, it has federated its own newsletter, making it the first federated Ghost instance on the internet.

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Users can follow the newsletter through their preferred federated app at @index@activitypub.ghost.org, though the company warns there will be bugs and issues as it continues to work on the platform's integration with [ActivityPub](#), the protocol that powers Mastodon and other federated apps.

"Having multiple Ghost instances in production successfully running ActivityPub is a huge milestone for us because it means that for the first time, we're interacting with the wider fediverse. Not just theoretical local implementations and tests, but the real world wide social web," the company shared in its announcement of the news.

In addition, Ghost's ActivityPub GitHub repository is now fully open source. That means those interested in tracking Ghost's progress toward federation can follow its code changes in real time, and anyone else can learn from, modify, distribute or contribute to its work. Developers who want to collaborate with Ghost are also being invited to get involved following this move.

The company had earlier detailed the benefits of an ActivityPub integration as an alternative to closed platforms, like Substack and others.

By offering a federated version of the newsletter, readers will have more choices on how they want to subscribe. That is, instead of only being able to follow the newsletter via email or the web, they also can track it using RSS or ActivityPub-powered apps, like Mastodon and others. Ghost said it will also develop a way for sites with paid subscribers to manage access via ActivityPub, but that functionality hasn't yet rolled out with this initial test.

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ActivityPub integration is becoming more common in the media business, as writers and publishers grapple with reduced traffic from sources like Google and Facebook while AI technology summarizes their work, either through paid [content deals](#) or [plagiarism](#). Several sites, including The Verge, MacRumors and MacStories (and soon TechCrunch) recently adopted a [new feature that will add their reporters' bylines to news articles](#) when they appeared in the fediverse, for instance.

Ghost itself has also [attracted](#) several high-profile users to its platform, often because Substack's lax moderation policies meant it was [increasingly becoming a home for hate speech](#). Casey Newton, formerly of The Verge, [left Substack](#) this year due to moderation concerns and [migrated](#) to Ghost instead. Another newsletter, [Garbage Day, also left](#) Substack. Other popular Ghost-powered publishers include 404 Media, Buffer, Kickstarter, David Sirota's The Lever and Tangle, to name a few.

Topics: [fediverse](#) [ghost](#) [Mastodon](#) [newsletter](#)

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is [structured as a nonprofit](#) — is considering federating Ghost over ActivityPub, the social networking protocol that powers the fediverse.

O’Nolan said that the most requested feature over the past few years has been to federate his software. “It seems like there are many potential ways to do it. Curious to hear how you would want it to work?” he asked in [a post on Threads](#), which was syndicated to Mastodon via Threads’ own integration with ActivityPub.

The survey asks users if they use any ActivityPub platforms like Mastodon or Threads, and how they would expect ActivityPub functionality to work in Ghost, if it were to be added. It also asks how federation would personally benefit Ghost users. It invites survey respondents to optionally provide an email address if they want to be contacted for more input in the future, as well.

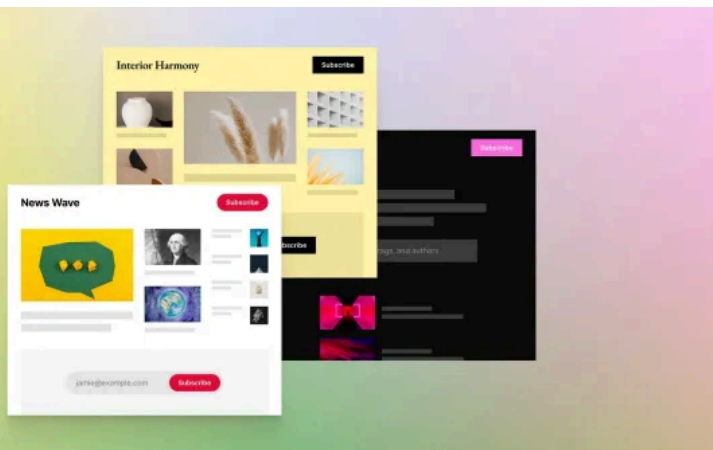


IMAGE CREDITS: GHOST

While the launch of a survey isn’t necessarily a commitment to federating Ghost, it is another signal pointing to the [broader reshaping of the web that’s now underway](#).



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Following Twitter’s acquisition by billionaire Elon Musk, online users have experienced the downsides of putting their trust in centralized platforms: With a shift in ownership, Twitter was overhauled to be a different type of platform called X, with revised ethics and long-term ambitions. (Musk wants X to be an “everything” app for transactions, creator content, video, shopping and more and takes a more hands-off role in terms of content moderation.)

For those unhappy with Musk’s changes, having a portable social networking identity suddenly seemed like an idea that had more value. That is, if you don’t like the way your Mastodon server (or other federated service) is run, you can pick up your profile and move it elsewhere, [followers in tow](#).

With Ghost, however, the idea could be to federate the accounts of the writers who use Ghost to publish their content. Their posts, which would also be published on the web and to their newsletter subscribers, could also exist in the fediverse, where others could read, like and reply to the post from their preferred app. These replies could also potentially syndicate back to Ghost, where they could exist as comments.



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Assuming Ghost went this route, it would be similar to how [WordPress federated](#) with ActivityPub after the [acquisition of](#) an ActivityPub blog plug-in. When enabled, WordPress blogs can be followed by people on apps like Mastodon and others in the fediverse and then receive replies as comments on their own sites.

After seeing O’Nolan’s post, Mastodon CTO Renaud Chaput [reached out to help](#) with the ActivityPub integration, which O’Nolan accepted.

Ghost has gained attention as a Substack rival in recent months for the same reason that some have fled X: People disagree about how platforms should be moderated. Substack has taken to promoting free speech, as Musk does on X, but that’s also led to the platform [being used by pro-Nazi publications](#), as detailed by The Atlantic late last year.

As a result, one of Substack’s more high-profile writers, Casey Newton, formerly of The Verge, [left Substack](#) and [migrated](#) to Ghost instead.

“I’m not aware of any major U.S. consumer internet platform that does not explicitly ban praise for Nazi hate speech, much less one that welcomes them to set up shop and start selling subscriptions,” Newton wrote at the time.

In addition to Newton, [other notable Ghost users](#) include 404 Media, Buffer, Kickstarter, David Sirota’s The Lever and Tangle, to name a few.

Today, Ghost has been installed [over 3 million times](#), which would make for a healthy addition to the wider fediverse and its roughly [13+ million total users](#), around 1.5 million of which are active

monthly. (This figure doesn't include Threads' [130+ million monthly active users](#) as it's not fully integrated with [ActivityPub](#) as of yet.)

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Substack rival Ghost confirms it will join the fediverse in 2024

[Ghost](#), an open source rival to Substack's newsletter platform, has confirmed it will this year officially join the fediverse — or the open social network of interconnected servers that includes apps like [Mastodon](#), Pixelfed, PeerTube, [Flipboard](#) and, more recently, [Instagram Threads](#), among others. Last week, the company teased its plans by [surveying](#) its users about how they may want federation to work.

Founder John O'Nolan had [explained](#) in a post on Threads that there are many potential ways that Ghost could leverage federation in its software but wanted to know how users would expect things to work.

IMAGE CREDITS:

GHOST (EDITED BY BRYCE DURBIN/TECHCRUNCH)

According to some replies, the hope was that Ghost's blog and newsletter authors would become fediverse accounts, while each of their posts would be federated to the fediverse. This would allow users to follow Ghost's authors from their preferred app, as well as like and reply to their posts from the fediverse. These replies could then be posted back on the author's site as a blog comment. Ghost said it expects to add tens of millions of users to the fediverse when integration is completed. In total, the fediverse is expected to reach 170 to 200 million users by this summer, when including Instagram Threads in the total.



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This setup is similar to how [WordPress federated](#) with ActivityPub, the protocol powering the fediverse, after [acquiring](#) an ActivityPub blog plugin. When enabled, WordPress blogs can be followed by people on apps like Mastodon and others in the fediverse and then receive replies as comments on their own sites.

Ghost's announcement last week set off a flurry of activity, including outreach from Mastodon CTO Renaud Chaput, [who offered to help out](#) with the ActivityPub integration.

On Monday, Ghost [officially confirmed its plans to federate](#) its service in 2024 and detailed how it would work.

The company explained that Ghost publishers would “soon” be able to follow, like, and interact with one another in the same way as they normally would on a social network, but from their own website. Plus, they'll be able to follow, like, and interact with users on other federated services like Mastodon, Threads, Flipboard, Buttondown, WriteFreely, WordPress, PeerTube, Pixelfed, and others.

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Meanwhile, an ActivityPub-powered feed will be built into Ghost so users can follow the people, publications, and topics of interest to them from around the web. They'll also be able to subscribe to these sites via ActivityPub, in addition to RSS. And when Ghosts' authors publish, their posts will appear on networks like Mastodon and others.

Ghost's announcement detailed the benefits of an ActivityPub integration, noting that each platform could design how it wants to present its content while still being compatible with other services. Readers will also have more choices in how they want to subscribe to an author's content — via email subscriptions, RSS, or ActivityPub. Gated access for sites with paid subscriptions can also be managed through ActivityPub, but Ghost hasn't yet shared exactly how this aspect would work, only that it will do its best to "create a seamless experience."

"And, because this technology is all open, you remain in full control of your subscribers," the blog post states. "When you publish a new piece online, your distribution comes from your own website rather than needing to depend on third parties."

Ghost has generated increased interest in recent months as more high-profile authors have made the switch.

Notably, Casey Newton, formerly of The Verge, [left Substack](#) and [migrated](#) to Ghost instead over concerns about how Substack moderated — or rather didn't moderate — some of the content on its platform. [Garbage Day left](#) as well. Other popular publishers include 404 Media, Buffer, Kickstarter, David Sirota's The Lever, and Tangle, to name a few.



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